

CHAPTER SIX

STRESS MANAGEMENT

Chapter outline

- Definition of stress
- ~~Types of stress~~
- Personal stressor
- Work place stressors
- Symptoms of work related stress
- Causes of work related stress
- Benefits of preventing stress
- Managing stress

Stress management

What is stress?

- **Stress** is the feeling of being under too much mental or emotional pressure.
- Pressure turns into **stress** when you feel unable to cope. People have different ways of reacting to **stress**, so a situation that feels **stressful** to one person may be motivating to someone else.
- **Stress** is defined by psychologists as the body's reaction to a change that requires a physical, mental, or emotional adjustment or response.
- Stress is an inevitable feature of life. It is the force that gets us out of bed in the morning, motivates us at the gym, and inspires us to work.

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- unmanaged stress could create physical diseases such as ulcers and high blood pressure, and psychological illnesses such as depression.
- Stress is a feeling that people have when they are struggling to cope with challenges related to finances, work, relationships, environment, and other situations. Moreover, stress is felt when an individual perceives a real or imagined challenge or threat to their well-being

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- How we perceive a stress provoking event and how we react to it determines its impact on our health. We may be motivated by the events in our lives, or we may see some as “stressful” and respond in a manner that may have a negative effect on our physical, mental, and social well-being.
- If we always respond in a negative way, our health and happiness may suffer. By understanding ourselves and our reaction to stress-provoking situations, we can learn to handle stress more effectively.
- To learn stress management is to learn about the mind-body connection and to the degree to which we can control our health in a positive sense.

Types of stress

- According to American Psychological Association (APA), there are 3 different types stress — acute stress, episodic acute stress, and chronic stress.

1. *Acute stress:* is a very short-term type of stress that can either be positive or more distressing; this is the type of stress we most often encounter in day-to-day life.

For example, if you have recently been involved in an argument, you may have acute stress related to negative thoughts that are repetitive about the argument. Or you may have acute stress that is about an upcoming work deadline, again the stress is thought induced.

Types of stress

2. *Episodic acute stress*: is when acute stresses happen on a frequent basis. Some people seem to experience acute stress over and over. These kind of repetitive stress episodes may be due to a series of very real stressful challenges.

For example, losing a job, then developing health problems, followed by difficulties for a child in the school setting.

3. *Chronic stress*: is stress that seems never-ending and inescapable.

It is the most harmful type of stress. If chronic stress is left untreated over a long period of time, it can significantly and often irreversibly damage your physical health and deteriorate your mental health. For example, long term poverty, repeated abuse in any form, unemployment, dysfunctional family, poor work environment, substance abuse, or an unhappy marriage can cause significant chronic stress. Chronic stress can also set in when an individual feels hopeless, does not see an escape from the cause of stress, and gives up on seeking solutions.

TYPES OF STRESS

- **Distress:**

Stress due to an excess of adaptive demands placed upon us. The demands are so great that they lead to bodily and mental damage.

e.g.: unexpected death of a loved one.

- **Eustress:**

The optimal amount of stress, which helps to promote health and growth.
e.g.: praise from a superior for hard working.

Personal stressors

- A stressor is an event or situation that causes stress.
- **Stressors** are events or contexts that cause a stress reaction by elevating levels of adrenaline and forcing a physical or mental response.
- Understanding what can potentially cause stress can help avoid negative consequences. Now we will examine the major personal stressors in the workplace.

Personal stressors

- **Negative personal stressors (distresses) can include:**
- The death of a partner/ family member
- Losing contact with loved ones/ Filing for divorce
- Hospitalization (oneself or a family member)
- Being abused or neglected
- Conflict in interpersonal relationships
- Bankruptcy/money problems
- Unemployment
- Sleep problems
- Legal problems
- Excessive job demands
- Job insecurity
- Conflicts with team mates and supervisors
- Lack of training necessary to do a job
- Unproductive and time-consuming meetings.

Personal stressors

- **positive personal stressors(Eustress) might include:**
- Receiving a promotion at work
- Starting a new job
- Marriage or commitment ceremony
- Buying a home
- Having a child
- Taking or planning a vacation
- Retiring
- Taking educational classes or learning a new hobby(e.g. computer training)

Workplace stressors

- A major category of workplace stressors are:
- **Role Demands:** *relate to pressures placed on a person as a function of the particular role he or she plays in the organization.*
- **Role ambiguity:** refers to vagueness in relation to what our responsibilities are. If you have started a new job and felt unclear about what you were expected to do, you have experienced role ambiguity

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- **Role conflict:** refers to facing contradictory demands at work. For example, your manager may want you to increase customer satisfaction and cut costs, while you feel that satisfying customers inevitably increases costs.
- **Role overload:** is defined as having insufficient time and resources to complete a job.

Symptoms of work-related stress

- The signs or symptoms of work-related stress can be physical, psychological and behavioral.
- **Physical** symptoms include:
 - ☞ Fatigue
 - ☞ Muscular tension
 - ☞ Headaches
 - ☞ Heart palpitations
 - ☞ Sleeping difficulties, such as insomnia

Symptoms of work-related stress

Psychological symptoms include:

- Depression
- Anxiety
- Discouragement
- Irritability
- Pessimism
- Feelings of being overwhelmed and unable to cope
- Cognitive difficulties, such as a reduced ability to concentrate or make decisions.

Symptoms of work-related stress

Behavioral symptoms include:

- An increase in sick days or absenteeism
- Aggression
- Diminished creativity and initiative
- A drop in work performance
- Problems with interpersonal relationships
- Mood swings and irritability
- Lower tolerance of frustration and impatience
- Disinterest
- Isolation.

Causes *of work-related stress*

Some of the factors that commonly cause work-related stress include:

- ⇒ Long hours work
- ⇒ Heavy workload and/or Insufficient skills for the job
- ⇒ Changes within the organization results in Changes to duties
- ⇒ Tight deadlines
- ⇒ Lack of autonomy
- ⇒ Boring work
- ⇒ Over-supervision & Poor r/ships with colleagues or bosses
- ⇒ Lack of proper resources
- ⇒ Few promotional opportunities
- ⇒ Harassment
- ⇒ Discrimination and so on.

Benefits of preventing stress in the workplace

- ✓ Reduced symptoms of poor mental and physical health
- ✓ Fewer injuries, less illness and lost time
- ✓ Reduced sick leave usage, absences and staff turnover
- ✓ Increased productivity
- ✓ Greater job satisfaction
- ✓ Increased work engagement
- ✓ Reduced costs to the employer
- ✓ Improved employee health and community wellbeing.

Stress management

It is the amelioration of stress and especially chronic stress often for the purpose of improving everyday functioning.

Stress produces numerous symptoms which vary according to persons, situations, and severity. These can include physical health decline as well as depression.



Because low to moderate levels of stress can be functional and lead to higher performance, management may not be concerned when employees experience them.



DEFINITION

$$S = P > R$$

Stress occurs when the pressure is greater than the resource

Individual Approaches for stress management

- An employee can take personal responsibility for reducing stress levels. Individual strategies that have proven effective include ***time-management techniques***, increased physical exercise, relaxation training, and expanded ***social support networks***.
- A few of the best-known time-management principles are (1) *making daily lists of activities to be accomplished* (2) *prioritizing activities by importance and urgency* (3) *scheduling activities according to the priorities set* (4) *knowing your daily cycle and handling the most demanding parts of your job when you are most alert and productive* and (5) *avoiding electronic distractions* like frequently checking e-mail, which can limit attention and reduce efficiency.

Individual Approaches

- Physicians have recommended non-competitive ***physical exercise*** , such as Walking, jogging, swimming, and riding a bicycle, as a way to deal with excessive stress levels.
- These activities increase lung capacity, lower the at-rest heart rate, and provide a mental diversion from work pressures, effectively reducing work-related levels of stress.

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Individual Approaches

- Individuals can also teach themselves to reduce tension through ***relaxation techniques*** such as meditation, hypnosis & deep breathing.
- The objective is to reach a state of deep physical relaxation, in which you focus all your energy on release muscle tensions.
- Deep relaxation for 15 to 20 minutes a day releases strain and provides a pronounced sense of peacefulness, as well as significant changes in heart rate, blood pressure, and other physiological factors.

Individual Approaches

- Social connections like friends, family, or work colleagues can also provide an outlet when stress levels become excessive.
- Expanding your social *support network* provides someone to hear your problems and offer a more objective perspective on a stressful situation than your own.

Organizational Approaches

- Strategies to consider include improved employee selection and job placement, training, realistic goal-setting, redesign of jobs, increased employee involvement, improved organizational communication, employee sabbaticals, and corporate wellness programs.

Organizational Approaches

- Certain jobs are more stressful than others but individuals differ in their response to stressful situations.
- We know individuals with little experience or an external locus of control tend to be more prone to stress.
- Selection and placement decisions should take these facts into consideration.
- Similarly, *training* can increase an individual's self-efficacy and thus lessen job strain.
- Managers should also consider increasing *employee involvement* in decision making, because evidence clearly shows that increases in employee empowerment reduce psychological strain.

Organizational Approaches

- Increasing formal organizational *communication* with employees reduces uncertainty by lessening role ambiguity and role conflict.
- Sabbaticals —ranging in length from a few weeks to several months —allow employees to travel, relax (*wellness program*), or pursue personal projects that consume time beyond normal vacations.
- Proponents say they can recover and refresh workers who might otherwise be headed for burnout.

Thank you

Questions and Comments

